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HOW THE BJP BECAME THE WORLD'S LARGEST POLITICAL PARTY

Organisational Restructuring and the Use of Digital Technologies

It would have gone unnoticed any other Sunday morning. Vinay Sahasrabuddhe, then BJP vice president, MP and head of the party's Good Governance and Policy Research cells, woke up, planted a party flag outside his Ashoka Road residence in central Delhi and tweeted a picture of himself with it.[1] 'As directed by the @BJP4India leadership hoisted Party flag at my residence and thereby paid tributes to all those whose painstaking efforts made us the largest political Party of the world!' read the accompanying message. 'We are proud of our Party's democratic credentials.'[2]

This was at the height of India's first COVID-19 lockdown. Prime Minister Modi had called on every Indian to light a lamp at their doorstep at 8 p.m. that evening to honour all healthcare and essential services workers. Normal work had long been suspended across the country. But Sunday, 6 April 2020, was also the BJP's Foundation Day, the fortieth anniversary of its inception. And so, in the middle of the national emergency, the party's leaders decided to continue what they call 'sangathan' (organisation) work, but with a COVID-19 twist.

Party President J.P. Nadda had issued an eight-point directive to all party workers. In view of the lockdown, they were to celebrate